

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman analyzes the Gemara's description of Rosh Hashanah's unique "avodah"—**מלכיות, זכרונות, ושופרות**—and explains why the Torah's pesukim leave Rosh Hashanah's core themes (judgment and coronation) so hidden. Drawing on the Ramban, Rabbi Shulman frames this concealment as an act of mercy: Hashem gives Am Yisrael advance notice of judgment, while the rest of the world is judged without realizing it. He then develops (via the Maharal) how the three sections of Mussaf form one progression: coronating Hashem leads to judgment, and the shofar turns lofty thoughts into lived, emotional transformation—like the shofar at Har Sinai made Torah real in the world.

I. The puzzle: Rosh Hashanah seems unclear from the pesukim

A. The Gemara's "what to do on each chag" framework

- Rabbi Shulman opens with the Gemara in Rosh Hashanah reviewing each holiday's defining practice (e.g., matzah on Pesach, Torah on Shavuot).
- Rosh Hashanah is harder to identify from the Torah alone: it is described as **יום תרועה** and **יום זכרון**, but the "why" is not explicit.

B. Ramban's question: how would anyone know what Rosh Hashanah is about?

- Even knowing there is shofar-blowing, the Torah does not plainly state:
 - that it is a **day of coronation** of Hashem
 - that it is a **day of judgment**
 - Rabbi Shulman notes that an outsider reading only the Torah text would not be able to deduce "Day of Judgment" from the pesukim.
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II. The Gemara's formulation: Malchuyot, Zichronot, and Shofar (2:00)

A. The key Gemara

- Rabbi Shulman cites the Gemara's instruction:
 - "אמרו לפני בראש השנה מלכיות, זכרונות, ושופרות."
 - "מלכיות כדי שתמליכוני עליכם" (Malchuyot: so you coronate Me over you)
 - "זכרונות כדי שיעלה זכרוניכם לפני לטובה" (Zichronot: so your remembrance rises before Me for good)
 - "ובמה? בשופר" (And through what? Through the shofar)

B. The shofar's "dual role" (a textual oddity)

- Rabbi Shulman highlights a structural tension:
 - **Shofar appears as its own section**(pesukim, like Malchuyot and Zichronot 10—שופרות)
 - Yet **the shofar is also the instrument** by which all three sections are "activated": **ובמה? בשופר**
- This raises a question: if shofar is mainly a vehicle for the first two, why does it also require its own independent section of pesukim?

C. Mussaf structure as we practice it

- In Mussaf we recite three sections—Malchuyot, Zichronot, Shofarot—each built from pesukim (traditionally 10).
 - Each section is followed by shofar-blowing, matching the Gemara's description.
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III. Why the Torah keeps Rosh Hashanah's essence hidden (Ramban) (10:00)

A. Concealment is intentional: Hashem does not "announce" the audit date

- Rabbi Shulman brings the Ramban's idea with an analogy:
 - A surprise audit is more effective than an announced one.
- So too, Hashem judges the entire world, yet the Torah does not openly declare the universal "judgment day."

B. For Am Yisrael, concealment is itself mercy

- Rabbi Shulman explains the Ramban's key point:
 - Strict judgment would be: surprise inspection, then punishment.
 - Mercy is: giving a **heads up** so we can prepare and do teshuvah.
- Therefore, the Torah uses **hints** (shofar; "remembrance") rather than an explicit "Day of Judgment" declaration.

C. Another hint: the proximity of Yom Kippur

- Rabbi Shulman adds the Ramban's additional clue:
 - Yom Kippur is a day of forgiveness/pardon.
 - A pardon implies a prior conviction/judgment.
 - Therefore, the juxtaposition hints that **Rosh Hashanah must be judgment**.
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IV. Why Malchuyot is not written explicitly in the Torah (and the parallel to "Anochi Hashem") (15:00)

A. The Torah's silence: "Where is Malchuyot in the Rosh Hashanah pesukim?"

- Rabbi Shulman notes:
 - The Torah at least hints to shofar (יום תרועה) and remembrance (יום זכרון).
 - But it does not even hint clearly to **Malchuyot**.

B. The broader issue: counting mitzvot and the first of the Aseret HaDibrot

- Rabbi Shulman discusses the classic question (noted in Ramban's comments on the mitzvah count):
 - Why is "אנכי ה' אלקיך" (I am Hashem your God) not phrased like a command ("You shall...")?

C. Ramban/Midrash: a king cannot command people to accept his kingship

- Rabbi Shulman explains the circularity:
 - If a king must command, "Listen to my commands," then he is not yet accepted as king.
 - If he is already king, such a command is unnecessary.

- Therefore, "אנכי ה' אלקיך" is a **statement of fact**, not an edict.
 - Parallel application to Rosh Hashanah:
 - Hashem does not "command" us to coronate Him as King *as if it were creating kingship from nothing*.
 - Rather, Malchuyot is our recognition and acceptance of an existing reality: Hashem already is King.
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V. Why three themes on one day? The Maharal: they are one progression (23:30)

A. The question

- Rabbi Shulman asks why Rosh Hashanah seems to bundle "three jobs" into one day:
 - Malchuyot
 - Zichronot
 - Shofarot
- This is reflected in the unusual length and complexity of Rosh Hashanah Mussaf.

B. The Maharal's answer: not three independent ideas, but one unfolding process

- Malchuyot → Zichronot → Shofarot is a natural sequence, each stage leading to the next.

C. Stage 1: Malchuyot—Rosh Hashanah as היום הרת עולם

- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - Rosh Hashanah is the anniversary of creation (היום הרת עולם).
 - Recognizing Hashem as Creator means acknowledging Him as **King**.

D. Stage 2: Zichronot—kingship implies judgment

- Rabbi Shulman develops the idea:
 - A king is the ultimate judge; governance requires deciding outcomes and roles.
 - He adds a Ramchal-style framing: creation is renewed yearly, so roles are reassigned.
- Judgment as "employment placement"
 - Rabbi Shulman uses a practical metaphor:
 - Judgment is like being assigned your role in the "company" for the coming year.
 - Who will be placed where in the world's mission depends partly on who we have become through our actions.

VI. What “Zichronot” really means: Hashem “remembering” us for good (28:30)

A. The theological problem: does Hashem forget?

- Rabbi Shulman notes the apparent implication of “remembering”:
 - Memory suggests prior forgetting.
 - But Hashem does not have memory lapses.
- Connected example:
 - A preference for a ram’s horn is described as “reminding” Hashem of Akeidat Yitzchak—yet Hashem needs no reminder.

B. Maharal’s conceptual model: “forgetting” as being covered over

- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - Forgetting is not always erasure; it can mean:
 - earlier knowledge is **covered** by later layers of knowledge.
 - A reminder “pulls up” the foundational truth from under what obscures it.

C. Applied to divine judgment: essence vs. external record

- Hashem “knows” two layers about us:
 1. Our deep identity: הנשמה, who we were created to be, our potential.
 2. The “superimposed” layer: the negative externals—mistakes, distractions, sins.
- Zichronot means we ask Hashem:
 - not to judge only by the superficial layer,
 - but to “remember” the deeper truth about who we are—**לטובה** (for good).

D. Human parallel: we also “forget who we are”

- Rabbi Shulman turns it inward:
 - People forget the person they dreamed they could be.
 - Daily life becomes an alternate identity.
- Rosh Hashanah is the time to reclaim that inner self in judgment.

E. Universal need

- Rabbi Shulman notes:
 - No one is perfect—**אין צדיק בארץ שיעשה טוב ולא יחטא** (quoted conceptually).

- Therefore, everyone needs this plea: to be seen through the lens of inner potential and mercy, not only external failure.
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VII. Why shofar: turning thought into emotional reality (36:00)

A. The last step: Shofarot follows Zichronot

- Rabbi Shulman describes the human experience:
 - We remember something important—then forget again.
 - So we externalize the memory (notes, alarms) to prevent it from fading.

B. Shofar as spiritual “externalization”

- Shofar is the mechanism that takes:
 - abstract awareness (mind),
 - and moves it into lived experience (heart).
- Rabbi Shulman argues:
 - The mind alone is “weak” compared to the force of emotion.
 - requires speaking words (not only thinking them), because speech brings inner תפילה לכן, meaning into the world.

C. The shofar’s sound: making Malchuyot and Zichronot transformative

- The loud, piercing shofar blast ensures:
 - Malchuyot isn’t just an idea about Hashem’s kingship,
 - Zichronot isn’t just a fleeting meditation about who we could be,
 - but becomes a destabilizing, world-shaking experience that changes us.

D. Shofarot pesukim and Har Sinai

- Rabbi Shulman notes that Shofarot pesukim in Mussaf come from the Sinai experience:
 - Torah at Sinai was not only serene spirituality; it arrived with overwhelming קול שופר.
 - Lesson:
 - Without that “bursting” presence, Torah risks remaining abstract.
 - Shofar gives Torah and these Rosh Hashanah ideas “reality” in this world.
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VIII. In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman explains (via the Ramban) that the Torah intentionally conceals Rosh Hashanah's judgment theme as an act of mercy: the world is judged without knowing, but Jews are given hints and advance warning.
- He clarifies why Malchuyot is not commanded explicitly: coronating Hashem is recognition of an existing reality, like "אנכי ה' אלקיך" is a fact-statement rather than a command.
- He presents the Maharal's model that Malchuyot, Zichronot, and Shofarot are one progression: kingship leads naturally to judgment, and judgment requires seeking to be seen "לטובה."
- He defines Zichronot as asking Hashem to "remember" our essential נשמה and potential beneath the external record of mistakes.
- He frames shofar as the tool that brings lofty ideas out of the mind and into the heart—transforming Rosh Hashanah from reflection into lived change, echoing the shofar of Har Sinai.